

Sample Wilderness Key and Maps

Note: This example is intended for the DM's use only. If players wish to adventure in this sample wilderness, stop reading here. The following information is for the DM to describe to the players as they explore.

Map: Grand Duchy of Karameikos

General Notes: The scale of this map is 6 miles per hex and the map shows a section of the Grand Duchy of Karameikos. The Duchy is a large tract of wilderness and unsettled land claimed by Duke Stefan Karameikos the Third. Although he claims control of a large area of land on paper, large portions of it are held by humanoids and monsters. The two main settled areas are the coast near the main city of Specularum and the Black Eagle Barony on the Gulf of Halag.

The weather throughout the area represented on this map is generally temperate and mild with short winters of little or no snowfall and long summers. Rainfall is ample but not heavy and easterly winds blow cool breezes from over the sea.

The mountain range running along the north edge of the map is known by different names by the peoples of the territory including the Black Peaks, the Cruth Mountains, or The Steach. The two large river systems that provide drainage from the area are left for the DM to name.

Due to the climate, large sections of this map are heavily forested. Humans engage in lumber operations near the edges of the forests, but are loathe to venture too deeply without good cause. Timber, both hardwood and softwood, is a prime resource of the area, and is either exported or used to build ships in the shipyards of the port of Specularum.

HUMAN LANDS

Specularum — Originally a trading port founded when this area was first explored, Specularum has become the major city of the Grand Duchy of Karameikos. Approximately 5,000 people live in or immediately around the city. The Duke maintains a standing force of 500 troops and may raise an army of 5,000 from the surrounding countryside in times of war. A small fleet of warships is maintained in the harbor.

The city is primarily noted for its excellent harbor facilities and shipyards. Walled on the landward side, the city is also protected by 2 breakwaters that extend into the harbor, restricting passage to a narrow entrance. Overlooking the harbor is the Duke's castle, providing ample defense of the harbor.

Black Eagle Barony — This area of the Duchy has been given as a fiefdom to Baron Ludwig "Black Eagle" von Hendriks. The central town is Fort Doom, a forbidding structure. It is rumored to have dungeons filled with those who have displeased the Baron, an extremely cruel and unpopular man. The Baron may have possible connections with evil slavers and disreputable mercenaries. The Baron maintains a garrison of 200 troops, using them freely to quell dissent and crush attacking non-humans.

Luln — Composed primarily of persons who have fled Black Eagle Barony, merchants who have come to trade with the Baron, and some non-humans who have left the wilderness, Luln is a base town for adventurers exploring the Haunted Keep, also called Koriszegy Keep and the surrounding land. Somewhat lawless and open, the town can provide most of the basic needs to any group of adventurers. The town is poorly defended, relying on the goodwill and capabilities of both the Baron and the Duke for its defense. Approximately 500 people live in the town.

NON-HUMANS

Gnomes: Living in the hills, the gnomes are a quiet and solitary group. They make little effort to contact the outside world, but will deal with traders when such arrive. There are 620 gnomes living throughout this area. This number is divided between a large lair of 250 and several smaller outposts of no more than 100 each. A council of elders chosen by the gnomes, 1 from each outpost and 3 from the main lair, guides the members of the community in most decisions. This council will act as judges, handle trade, and distribute any money for the defense of the various outposts. However, any important decisions are decided by a general vote of the population. Strangers desiring to deal with the gnomes must first present their case to the elders for approval. Should this approval not be given (and the gnomes are extremely reluctant to involve themselves in the affairs of any outsider), the case will be closed. In the event that the council cannot decide, a general vote will be taken. If great differences prevent an outpost of the lair from agreeing peacefully on an issue, the dissident faction will leave and establish a new outpost in the area. In this manner, the gnomish lands are slowly growing, although disunity slows this somewhat.

The gnomes are excellent craftsmen, especially skilled in combining items of wood and metal. Their wares will bring good prices in human lands. Trade is rendered difficult, however, not only by the reluctance of the gnomes to deal, but also because the goblins of the forest and the gnomes are involved in frequent skirmishes.

Gnome Lair. When seen from the surface, this area will appear to be nothing but a number of game paths that wind and cross each other. However, hidden throughout the area, are carefully camouflaged doors and smokeholes leading to the burrows underneath. Each door has a peephole through which a gnome guard keeps a constant watch.

- A. Gnome Observation Points:** Set in the highest points of the hill, these observation points are small mounds that rise just above the surrounding grass. They are built with small slits in the mounds that provide an all around view to the 2 gnome guards in each observation point. If intruders approach, the guards will alert the others by sounding a silent whistle the tame giant moles will react to.
- B. Guard Posts:** Each entrance will have a guard post near it, containing 10 gnome guards. It is their duty to stop any attackers that manage to enter the burrow complex and hold them until reinforcements arrive. In each chamber is a gong of different pitch which will be sounded when attackers enter that area.
- C. Animal Traps and Pens:** These are pits, covered and difficult to distinguish from the surrounding area. Each pit is 10' deep and contains 1-6 giant ferrets that the gnomes have trained to hunt the rats and other small animals that might invade the burrow. The pits also serve as traps, opening under the weight of even fairly small animals. On each side of the pit is a secret catch that is used to lock the doors shut, allowing safe passage over the trap door.

The remaining areas would contain the living chambers, kitchens, council chambers, and storerooms for the gnomes who live in the burrow. These areas have been left for the DM to fill in and key. The walls, ceilings, and floors of the rooms and passageways are panelled with planks of hard wood so that no earth shows. Mounted on the walls about 20' apart are oil lamps that are only lit as they are needed. Rooms are furnished in a simple but colorful style and have many domestic items scattered about them.